

Prehabilitation: How Pre-Op Exercise Speeds Recovery

Patients who train before surgery often go home days earlier.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-22 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Patients who train before surgery often go home days earlier.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- **Watch the warning signs.** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/exercise-hub\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Many studies over recent years have looked at how being active before an operation can help people recover better. Systematic reviews, which gather and analyse findings from many individual studies, consistently show that patients who engage in structured exercise programmes before surgery often experience shorter hospital stays and fewer complications. This is particularly true for larger operations where recovery can be more challenging.

Randomised controlled trials, considered a strong form of evidence, have compared groups of patients who exercised before surgery with those who didn't. These trials frequently demonstrate that the pre-surgery exercise group has improved physical function both before and after their operation, and a quicker return to their usual activities. The benefits seem to extend across different types of surgery, including joint replacements and abdominal procedures.

Clinical guidelines from various medical and patient organisations now recommend pre-operative exercise as a valuable part of preparing for surgery. This advice is based on the growing body of evidence that highlights the positive impact on recovery times, patient well-being, and overall surgical outcomes.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Thinking 'rest is best':** Staying completely still before surgery can weaken muscles. *Try to keep moving gently within your comfort zone.*

* **Overdoing it too close to surgery:** Intensive new exercise right before an operation can lead to injury or fatigue. *Stick to your established routine or gentle activities in the final days.*

* **Ignoring pain signals:** Pushing through sharp or increasing pain isn't helpful and can cause harm. *Listen to your body and adjust activity as needed.*

* **Failing to discuss existing health conditions:** Not mentioning all your health issues to your team can affect your pre-op plan. *Be open and honest about your full health picture.*

* **Eating poorly:** Your body needs good nutrition to prepare for and recover from surgery. *Focus on a balanced diet with plenty of protein, fruit, and vegetables.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

While gentle activity is often encouraged, there are times when you should always seek advice from your doctor, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist. This is especially important if you notice any new or worsening symptoms that might affect your surgery or recovery.

* Sudden increase in joint pain or swelling that doesn't settle with rest. * New or unexplained fever or feeling generally unwell. * Significant, rapid loss of movement or strength in a joint or limb. * Signs of infection around an existing joint replacement, such as redness, warmth, or discharge. * Unexpected changes in how you respond to your usual pain medication.

Frequently Asked Questions

What kind of exercise is best before surgery? The best exercise is usually a mix of strengthening and light aerobic activity that you can manage comfortably. Walking, cycling, swimming, and gentle exercises prescribed by a physiotherapist are often suitable. Always discuss specifics with your clinical team.

How soon before surgery should I start exercising? Ideally, you should start as soon as you know you're having surgery. Even a few weeks of consistent, appropriate activity can make a positive difference. The longer you can prepare, the better the potential benefits.

Can I still exercise if I have arthritis? Yes, absolutely. Gentle, consistent movement is often beneficial for arthritis. Your clinical team or physiotherapist can guide you on safe and effective exercises that won't aggravate your condition but will help prepare your body for surgery.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about prehabilitation: how pre-op exercise speeds recovery?

Short answer: Prehabilitation involves exercising before surgery to improve recovery. Studies show that patients who engage in structured exercise programmes pre-operation often have shorter hospital stays and fewer complications. This can lead to improved physical function

and a quicker return to normal activities. Gentle, regular activity like walking, cycling, or swimming is often recommended to strengthen muscles and prepare the body for surgery.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk